

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 1.1

RHYTHM

BASIC DEFINITIONS:
PULSE, NOTE VALUES
RHYTHM SYLLABLES



PULSE AND RHYTHM

Pulse can be found in many natural phenomena – the heartbeat, for example, or man-made — the ticking of an old-fashioned clock, or we can produce it ourselves. But the pulse, in and of itself, does not constitute music yet.

There are many different ways of KEEPING THE PULSE.

1. walk in place
2. tap your foot in place
3. move your foot inside your shoe
4. tap with your finger or palm on your thigh
5. clap

Some are, obviously, more useful in church than others.

RHYTHM refers to the patterns that occur as music moves through time.

We have a starting point (before the music begins) and an ending point (when the music ends). In between we have rhythm.

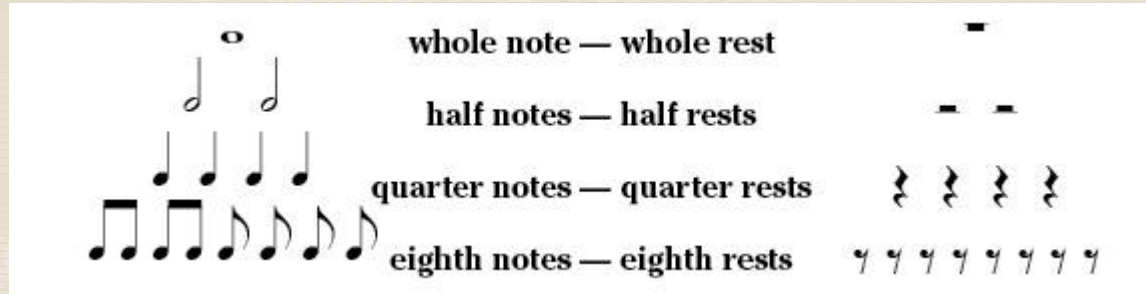
When music happens, it occurs in what we call “rhythmic units” that are **LAYERED OVER** the underlying pulse.

To write down musical rhythm, we use a series of symbols called **NOTES**. Depending on their duration in relation to one another, notes are said to have **value**.

Just as notes indicate the relative duration of musical sound, the relative duration of **silence** is indicated by **RESTS**.

Another common term for “pulse” is “**beat**.”

NOTE VALUES AND RESTS



- A **whole note** equals: 2 half notes or 4 quarter notes or 8 eighth notes
- A **half note** equals: 2 quarter notes or 4 eighth notes
- A **quarter note** equals: 2 eighth notes

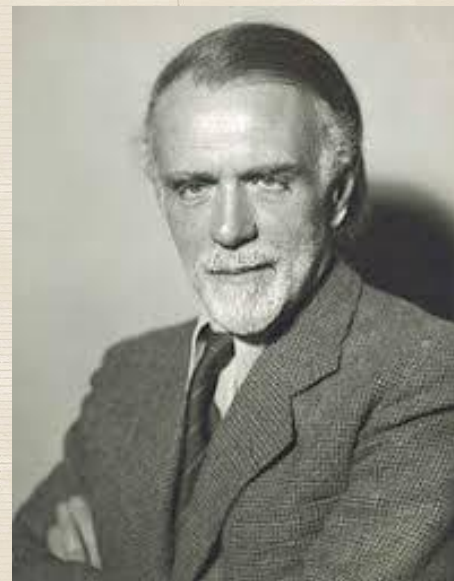
ZOLTÁN KODÁLY

Zoltán Kodály (1882-1967) was a Hungarian composer and music educator who developed a number of helpful tools and techniques (including Movable-DO solfège) to achieve universal musical literacy—a goal that has been admirably achieved in Hungary.

For the teaching and practice of rhythm Kodály developed a system of rhythmic syllables, corresponding to different note values.

The basic pulse or “rhythmic unit” is expressed by the syllable “ta”.

Example 1: ta ta ta ta ta ta ta ta ...



KODÁLY RHYTHMIC SYLLABLES

When divided, the basic rhythmic unit “ta” is expressed by the naturally shorter syllables **“ti-ti”**

Example 2: ta ti-ti ta ti-ti ta ti-ti ta ti-ti ta ...

When doubled up, two basic rhythmic units are expressed by rearticulating the vowel: **“too-oo”**

Example 3: ta ta too-oo ta ta too-oo ta ta too-oo ...

When quadrupled, four basic rhythmic units are expressed by prolonging the sound: **“too-oo-ee-oo”**

Example 4: ta ta ta ta too-oo-ee-oo ta ta ta ta too-oo-ee-oo

or: too-oo too-oo too-oo-ee-oo ta ta too-too too-oo-ee-oo

RHYTHMIC SYLLABLES AND NOTE VALUES

If we relate Kodály's rhythmic syllables to note values and assign the basic rhythmic unit "ta" to a quarter note, we will get the following:

Example 1:



Example 2:



Example 3:



Example 4:

The image displays two rows of musical notation. Each row consists of rhythmic syllables written above notes. The notes are represented by a vertical line and a dot (quarter note) or a vertical line and an open circle (half note).
Row 1: The syllables are 'ta', 'ta', 'ta', 'ta', 'too-oo-ee-oo', 'ta', 'ta', 'ta', 'ta', and 'too-oo-ee-oo'. The first four 'ta' syllables are each above a quarter note. The 'too-oo-ee-oo' syllable is above a half note. The next four 'ta' syllables are each above a quarter note. The final 'too-oo-ee-oo' syllable is above a half note.
Row 2: The syllables are 'too-oo', 'too-oo', 'too-oo-ee-oo', 'ta', 'ta', 'too-oo', and 'too-oo-ee-oo'. The first two 'too-oo' syllables are each above a quarter note. The 'too-oo-ee-oo' syllable is above a half note. The next two 'ta' syllables are each above a quarter note. The final 'too-oo' syllable is above a quarter note, and the final 'too-oo-ee-oo' syllable is above a half note.

We will make use of Kodály's rhythmic syllables in this course, also adapting them for the specific requirements of Orthodox chant.

TABLE SUMMARIZING THE KODÁLY RHYTHMIC SYLLABLES

quarter notes	 ta ta ta ta
eighth notes	 ti - ti ti - ti ti - ti ti - ti
half notes	 too - oo too - oo
whole note	 too - oo - ee - oo

• BEST PRACTICES FOR SIGHT-SINGING

When sight-reading a new piece of music, analyze the rhythm first, using the system of rhythmic syllables. Once the rhythm is solid, singing the correct pitches becomes much easier.

Whenever you practice for this class, ALWAYS have a pulse going somewhere — tapping (silently) with your hand or your foot.

Always feel the beat!

MEASURES AND TIME SIGNATURES

In some music, the beats are organized into regular units called **measures (or bars)**, which are separated by vertical lines called **bar lines**.

The size of the measure is indicated by a fraction-like expression called a **time signature**. The top number indicates the number of beats in the measure, and the bottom number indicates the note value that gets the beat.

Some frequently encountered examples of time signatures:

$\frac{4}{4}$ or **C**

$\frac{2}{2}$ or **♩**

$\frac{2}{4}$

$\frac{3}{4}$

$\frac{3}{2}$

Other, more complex time signatures are seldom encountered in church music.

METERED VS. UNMETERED MUSIC

Music that has a time signature is said to be **metered**. Meter can be

- ❖ **regular** (unchanging) or
- ❖ **irregular** (changing every measure or so.)

A lot of Orthodox church music, particularly if it is based on chant, is written without a time signature, and is therefore said to be **unmetered**.

- ❖ In the case of unmetered music, the rhythm of the music is typically determined by the rhythmic structure of the verbal text.
- ❖ But some church music written without a time signature is actually metered, i.e., it has a regular, unchanging beat.

(We will be encountering both metered and unmetered music in this course.)

YOU ARE NOW READY TO SIGHT-READ SOME RHYTHMS!

Please proceed to RHYTHM EXERCISES 1.1

